

Practice Paper 44 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “On paper” / official versus real duties

1 mark for understanding that “on paper” refers to her **formal, written job description** (maintenance tasks).

1 mark for recognising that her **real** daily existence is much more than maintenance — it is **living alone in a large empty building** and being mentally **resilient** enough to cope with the solitude.

Q2. [2] — Greeting the armchairs

1 mark — She is **eccentric** / **imaginative** / **creative**: she invents personalities for inanimate objects.

1 mark — She is **contented in her solitude** / **resourceful**; she has found a polite, dignified way to soften the loneliness of an empty hotel rather than being distressed by it.

Q3. [2] — Care and respect for the building

1 mark each for any two of:

- She runs the taps in each bathroom “so that no pipe forgets what water is”.
- She opens and closes every shutter so they do not “seize up by February”.
- She dusts the long oak counter “though no one will check it, because the wood deserves better than to be forgotten”.

Each must be quoted or clearly paraphrased.

Q4. [2] — “Solemnly as if it were a sermon”

1 mark — The **simile** compares the radio broadcast to a **religious sermon**, suggesting she treats it with **seriousness, reverence and ritual attention**.

1 mark — It shows that her quiet, repetitive routine has acquired the **dignity of ceremony**: ordinary acts (listening to the weather) become important because they structure her day.

Q5. [2] — Talking to the radio

(a) [1]: She knows that talking aloud to an inanimate object is **unusual** / **odd** by normal social standards; the radio cannot of course reply.

(b) [1]: It is her **only conversation** for days at a time — the habit gives her **company** and a sense of **connection** that her isolation would otherwise deny her.

Q6. [1] — Evidence that the bell ringing was unusual

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- In “four winters at the hotel, the bell had rung exactly twice before”.
- Both previous rings were “the postman”, and “this was not the postman’s day”.
- She “put down the knife” — she stops what she is doing because the sound is unexpected.

Q7. [2] — “The colour of putty”

1 mark — Putty is **pale, greyish and lifeless**; the description shows Anya’s hands are **dangerously cold**, possibly close to frostbite — far worse than the polite “ten minutes” Anya has asked for.

1 mark — Seeing this **physical evidence of harm** tells the narrator that turning the young woman away would be irresponsible; she abandons the polite “ten minutes” plan and **insists Anya come properly inside**.

Q8. [1] — Anya’s attitude on arrival

1 mark — She is **polite, self-effacing** and **anxious not to impose**: she presents herself as a temporary visitor who will leave quickly, suggesting she has been brought up to be **considerate of others** and **not to ask for too much**.

Q9. [3] — Companionable silence

1 mark for identifying that the silence is **comfortable** / **unforced** / **shared**; **1 mark each** for **two** explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “She watched the kettle. I watched her watch the kettle.” — the parallel structure suggests **quiet, mutual attention** rather than awkwardness.
- The narrator **adds two more potatoes** without being asked — small acts of welcome fill the silence.
- The narrator gives her **dry socks** and **tea** — wordless kindness conveys hospitality without forcing conversation.
- Anya speaks “after a while, when the colour had returned to her hands” — the silence is allowed to **last as long as Anya needs**, suggesting the narrator’s patience.

Each detail must be quoted or clearly paraphrased **and** explained.

Q10. [2] — “Nothing — potato, leek, a heel of yesterday’s bread, a square of hard cheese”

1 mark — The word **nothing** shows the narrator’s **modesty** / **understatement** about what she has provided; she does not wish to make a show of her generosity.

1 mark — The carefully itemised list that follows quietly contradicts the word “nothing” — it is, in

fact, a **complete, warming, thoughtful meal**; the contrast reveals her **humility** and her quiet pride in what she has done.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **warm, gently humorous, contented, affectionate, quietly tender**.
(Reject: **sad, lonely** — these miss the warmth.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Boredom as “soil”

1 mark for understanding the **contrast**: boredom is **not an absence** / **not a gap to be filled** (“not a hole”).

1 mark for the positive image: boredom is the **fertile ground** / **starting condition** out of which valuable thinking **grows**; it is **productive**, not wasted.

Q13. [2] — What the brain does when drifting

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Consolidates memories.**
- **Knits together** / **connects loose ideas.**
- **Rehearses plans for the future.**

Q14. [2] — Lancashire study result

1 mark — Participants were given a **deliberately tedious** / **boring task** (copying numbers from a telephone directory).

1 mark — Afterwards they produced **more original** / **creative ideas** on a standard test than the control group who had not done the boring task — boredom appeared to **boost** creativity.

Q15. [2] — Effect of the list of waiting activities

1 mark — The list illustrates that, until recently, **short pockets of doing nothing** were a **normal, unavoidable** part of daily life.

1 mark — By stacking ordinary examples (bus, kettle, train, walk home), the writer makes the reader **recognise their own lost moments** and prepares the contrast with the smartphone in the next sentence.

Q16. [2] — Effect of “abolished”

1 mark — **Abolished** is a strong, almost **legalistic** / **political** word, normally used for laws or institutions; it suggests the change has been **total and decisive**, not gradual.

1 mark — It conveys the writer’s view that something **valuable** has been **wiped out** — there is a hint of **regret** and **seriousness** about what has been lost.

Q17. [2] — “The issue is not screen time as such”

1 mark — The writer **anticipates a likely objection** — that he is simply attacking screens — and removes it before making his real point.

1 mark — It signals that the argument is more **nuanced**: screens used for **deep, sustained** content (a novel, a documentary) are fine; the problem is the **type** of stimulation, not its medium.

Q18. [2] — Rest vs mild, unending stimulation (own words)

1 mark — **Rest** means the mind is **truly unoccupied** / **allowed to wander**, free of external input.

1 mark — **Mild, unending stimulation** means a **continuous trickle of small rewards** / **distractions** that keep the brain **just busy enough** never to settle into the wandering, creative state.

Reject: answers that lift “continuous trickle of small rewards” without rewording.

Q19. [1] — Italicising **daydreaming**

1 mark — The italics **emphasise** the word and signal its **surprising** or **old-fashioned** quality — daydreaming has become so rare that teachers single it out as a noteworthy outcome of going phone-free. (Also accept: the italics mark it as the word teachers themselves use.)

Q20. [1] — Why first attempts feel “mildly distressing”

1 mark — The brain has become **accustomed** / **addicted** to constant input; removing it produces a sense of **restlessness, withdrawal or discomfort** — like any habit being broken.

Q21. [2] — “Seasons of growth and seasons of fallow”

1 mark — The **metaphor** compares the brain to **farmland**, which is a **living thing** that needs **rest as well as activity**; this makes the abstract idea concrete and intuitive.

1 mark — **Fallow** time is not waste — it is the period that **makes future growth possible**; denying it leads to a **thinner harvest**, i.e. poorer mental output. The image lends **natural inevitability** to the writer’s argument.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Why boredom benefits the brain (Paragraphs 2–4):

1. Boring tasks **boost creativity**: participants who did a tedious task produced **more original ideas** afterwards.
2. Unstructured time activates the brain’s **default mode network** / lets the mind **drift**.
3. In this drifting state the brain **consolidates memories** and **connects loose ideas** (also accept: rehearses future plans).
4. **Constant scrolling** gives only **mild, unending stimulation**, which **prevents** the brain from entering its wandering, creative state (rest is not the same as stimulation).

What schools, parents and individuals can do (Paragraphs 5–6):

5. **Schools** have introduced **phone-free breaks**, requiring pupils to leave devices in lockers between lessons.
6. **Parents** have introduced **phone-free family meals**, which lead to longer conversations.
7. **Individuals** can deliberately reclaim **small pockets of empty time** — walk without earphones, wait for the kettle without a phone, shower without a podcast, spend a few minutes doing nothing.
8. After about **two weeks**, those who try this report **clearer thinking, better sleep** and **new ideas** arriving unexpectedly.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Boredom appears to benefit the brain because deliberately dull tasks have been shown to raise creativity, and an unoccupied mind activates a network that consolidates memories and links loose ideas. Constant scrolling supplies mild rewards that block this restful drift. In response, some schools require phones in lockers between lessons, families eat without devices, and individuals can walk, wait or shower unplugged. After a fortnight, most report sharper thinking, sounder sleep and unexpected fresh ideas.

Length count: 78 words from “Boredom” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —